

for most people is choosing between a weak password that is easy to remember and is easy for hackers to crack, or a strong password that is hard to remember but much tougher for hackers to guess, even with their fancy-schmancy algorithms. We'll assume you go with the latter, since no security conscious individual would ever choose the former. First and foremost, never lift passwords from a dictionary, even if they are multiple words one after another. Such passwords are easy for hackers to figure out using a dictionary as a source dump for a brute force attack. To further secure your password, use special characters and a mixture of lowercase and uppercase letters, as well as numbers. In addition, longer passwords are better than shorter ones, since they become harder to crack with each character added. A rule of thumb is to keep a minimum length of 10 characters. Having said that a brute-force attack to guess the password will always succeed if enough time and processing power was available to the attacker. So, it is always recommended to change the passwords often. Try to keep the timing between every 4-6 months.

Then there's the general guidelines. Avoid using standard and repetitive sequences, and absolutely NO personal information should be included. If the hacker happened to have your personal information, don't make it easier for them to crack your password. And if you do happen to create a tough-to-remember and uncrackable password, make sure NOT to reuse it for any other account. As tempting as it sounds, it can have severe consequences for you in case the hacker knows the details of one account. This does bring us to the point of remembering your passwords for ALL your accounts, which numbers runs into tens for those active on the interwebs. It's considered smart to not write your details on paper, and instead use an encrypted password manager. As described in the previous chapter, a password manager requires you to remember only one master password, and the rest are generated and stored by the encrypted password vault itself. LastPass Premium and Dashlane are considered good alternatives for those willing to shell some money, while LastPass and LogMeOnce are available for those on a budget. Still, it's recommended that you invest in a paid password manager.

None of these will work if you're giving out your password left, right and center. Avoid sharing your password, and even if you have to, please, for the love of glob, don't email it to the other person. It's unnecessary and you will have only yourself to blame for such an egregious error. In other etiquette, avoid leaving your accounts logged in on public terminals, and